Five Knows

Student Workbook

S
Serena
Your AI guide

A clear, step-by-step way to plan your first working app.

1 What it does



Pick one simple, real job to do.

2 What it can do



Add the real features, one at a time.

3 What it shouldn't do



Set the truth rules that keep it honest.

4 How it looks and feels



See it first. The build starts here.

5 When it's done



One test that proves it, and how it gets better.



Pick one small app

Something you'd really use this week.

Go in order

Answer each Know before the next.

Keep it short

One sentence beats a paragraph.

Hand it to Claude

The finished workbook is your build prompt.

Our class example: a team organizer. People who had never built software had it working in about 20 minutes.

Know 1 · What it does

Define the one job your app takes off someone's plate.

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Your answers

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
Who uses it?	
What one job does it do for them?	
My app's job is to...	

Example: "My app's job is to give my team one shared list of tasks, so nothing gets dropped."

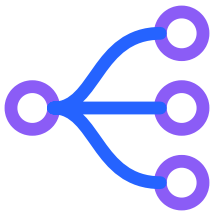
Serena's tip

If you need the word "and" to describe the job, you have two apps. Pick one now. Add the other on the next lap.

Know 2 · What it can do

List the real jobs your app does, one at a time.

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Start with three

#	IT CAN…	WHY IT'S NEEDED
1		
2		
3		

Example: 1. Add a task. 2. Mark it done. 3. Give it a due date.

Serena's tip

Every item here is something Claude has to build. Three is plenty for the first lap. Write the rest on the "next lap" page.

Know 3 · What it shouldn’t do

Set the truth rules that keep your app honest, legal and trustworthy.

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Truth rules, already on

- [x] Never makes things up. Says when it doesn’t know.
- [x] Shows where its information comes from.
- [x] Never does anything illegal, or anything that breaks my business’s rules.
- [x] Spells out what happens before it acts.
- [x] Uses real numbers only.

Rules for my business

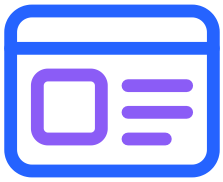
RULE	WHY

Finance or real estate? Add: “Plans and explains. Never tells a customer what to buy or sell.”

Know 4 · How it looks and feels

See it before you build it. This is where the build starts.

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Right brain, then left brain

1. Pick a feel: clean and professional, or friendly and approachable.
2. Give Knows 1 to 3 to Claude. Ask for an image prompt for ChatGPT that shows your main screen.
3. Make the look in ChatGPT. Tweak it until it feels right.
4. Bring the image and this workbook back to Claude to build.

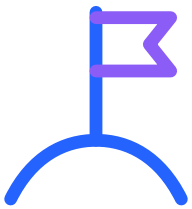
Your answers

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
The feel I want:	
Colors or brands I like:	
What it must never look like:	

Know 5 · When it's done

One test that proves it works, and the loop that makes it better.

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Done test

CHECK	PASS OR FAIL
Does it do its main job?	
Is it easy to understand and use?	
Does it follow my truth rules?	
Does it feel right for my business?	

If a check fails: go back to that Know, make one change, test again.



How it gets better

I'LL WATCH...	...AND THEN I'LL

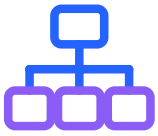
Example: watch which tasks go overdue; add a reminder the day before.

Think in systems

An app is a system, not a screen. Map it on one page.

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Loops, links, dependencies

PART OF THE SYSTEM	MY ANSWER
Loop: what feeds back and gets better?	
Links: what feeds what?	
Dependencies: what does it rely on? If that fails, what breaks?	

Your starter rules file

Save as CLAUDE.md in your project folder. Claude reads it every session. Add a rule each time you learn one the hard way.

```
# My Build Rules
## How to talk to me
- Short answers. Plain words, no jargon.
- Give me two choices and your recommendation.
- End every task by telling me how to check it worked.
## Truth rules
- Never make things up. Say when you don't know.
- Show where information comes from. Real numbers only.
- Nothing illegal. Nothing that breaks my business rules.
## Safety
- Never put passwords or keys in the code.
- Ask me before anything that costs money.
## Building
- Find when it last worked before fixing anything.
- Remove before you add. Save my work to GitHub after every step.
```

Run it again

Each lap adds one new piece, learned because your build needed it.

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The ladder of laps

LAP	THE NEW PIECE YOU'LL LEARN
1	Writing the outline, and getting the look right
2	GitHub, where your work is saved
3	Going live on the internet
4	Connecting an outside service, with a spend cap
5	Choosing the right AI for the job

After this lap

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
What worked?	
What surprised me?	
What do I add next lap?	

Keep the parts you build. Each one makes your next app faster. Ready for more? See smartplayapps.com/learn.